

KATHA STUDIO

Net of Lights

A Marina fisherwoman hauls up a net of stolen city light, then has to decide whether to sell it to the skyline or stitch it back into a hamlet the storm tried to unplug.

Book 10 · Sea fable · Chennai coast

Lead: Bommi Selvam · 22 pages



Original Indian graphic book · For personal reading



Marina at night is a rumour the Bay of Bengal tells the shore.

Thirty, salt in her hair, accounts in her head, a boat named after her late father because renaming felt like rudeness. The city's towers blink like they own the horizon.

NARRATOR

“Bommi fishes for a living. Tonight the living fishes back.”

SURF



The net comes up heavy with lamps, not fish — glowing, buzzing, smelling faintly of billboards.

Streetlight, kitchen tube, a temple's string of yellow bulbs, a hospital corridor's tired white. All of it wriggling like catch. Somewhere, she knows, rooms have gone unfairly dark.

BOMMI

“If you are current, you are in the wrong kitchen.”

FIZZ



Her sister in the hamlet calls: the lane is black, the child's homework is guessing.

Bommi looks at the glowing net, at the towers still blazing, and understands a theft the way she understands tides: not personal, but aimed.

SISTER

“Even the cat is walking into furniture. Come.”

PHONE



A man on the promenade offers cash for ‘ocean-sourced illumination, very exclusive’.

Bommi’s laugh is not kind. She has hauled prawn for clubs. She will not haul a hamlet’s eyesight for a DJ.

BUYER

“We can put it in a club. People pay to feel like weather.”

CASH



She rows toward the dark lane, net in the boat like a captured constellation.

Waves argue. She argues back, which is how her father taught navigation: with complaints that keep you awake.

BOMMI

“Hold on, little suns. You have addresses.”

OAR



Returning light is not as simple as plugging a fish into a wall.

They invent a rite that is also a wiring diagram: each bulb taken to the doorway it remembers. A temple bulb refuses a kitchen. A kitchen tube refuses a club, obviously.

ELECTRICIAN BOY

“Akka, this is not in my ITI notes.”

ZAP



The towers dim by a fraction, as if embarrassed.

Nobody in the towers is looking. Bommi does not wait for them. She looks at children writing multiplication under a returned tube-light, tongues out, alive.

NARRATOR

“Embarrassment is the beginning of policy, if anyone is looking.”

HUM



A coastal official wants the net as evidence, then as a photo op.

Bommi says name it with the hamlet's name, or do not name it. She lets him hold a bulb that stings slightly if you have made too many speeches.

OFFICIAL

“We will launch a scheme. Name it something with ‘smart’.”

CAMERA



Storm warning. The Bay stands up in its old way.

They pull the fleet. Kalsang is a goat in another book; here there is a dog named Meter who bites only ankles that come to steal motors. Meter is good at policy.

BOMMI

“Boats in. Lights in. Ego out.”

ROAR



After the storm, some lights have gone to sea again, loyal to no one.

Bommi says yes, because twice is how coasts work. She also says the towers must learn to keep their own glitter on their own roofs.

SISTER

“Will you fish them twice?”

DRIP



She takes a small glowing shard to a news channel, then regrets the makeup room.

Bommi says it is a fishing story. The anchor wants a villain. Bommi names a habit, which is harder to arrest and more accurate.

ANCHOR

“Is this magic or a power theft story?”

MIC



Women of the hamlet stitch a spare net with copper and old saris.

The net is ugly and strong. Bommi loves it the way she loves boats that have been patched until they are mostly stubbornness.

WOMAN

“If light wants to run, it will have to get through our mending.”

NEEDLE



A week of ordinary fish. Ordinary is a feast.

Children do homework in boring, legal electricity. Meter sleeps. The sea, professional, offers no editorials.

BOMMI

“Prawn, you I understand. Lamps, you were a phase.”

HAUL



Then a festival, and the towers try to drink the horizon again.

The sari-copper net holds. A few club lights go out during a drop, which the newspapers call a mystery and the hamlet calls Tuesday.

BOMMI

“Not this month. We have exams and a saint’s day.”

GLOW



Bommi's daughter — visiting from a hostel — wants to put the story in a project.

Bommi says say I fought a net, and the city happened to be in it. Precision is respect.

DAUGHTER

“Can I say you fought the city?”

PEN



They eat on the sand, lights of home behind them, towers ahead, sea beside, all in their lanes.

Fried fish. Onion. A joke about officials. Meter steals a bone. The Bay makes a sound like applause that is actually just waves, which is enough.

SISTER

“For once the dark is only the sky.”

CRACKLE



Bommi oils the boat named for her father and tells him, quietly, the week's accounts.

The boat does not answer. Boats are like that. Still, the telling matters.

BOMMI

“We returned more than we sold. You would have called that bad business and then smiled.”

CREAK



A young fisher from further south asks to copy the copper net.

Bommi draws the pattern in the sand, then on paper, then on the youth's phone, sighing at phones. Knowledge, like light, should travel without being stolen.

YOUTH

“Our hamlet's saint's day is next. The towers there are hungrier.”

ASK



Dawn. Marina joggers do not know they are jogging past a solved crime.

She sells fish to a woman in running shoes who says the sunrise is beautiful. Bommi agrees, and does not add that beauty is easier when your lane has a bulb.

NARRATOR

“Bommi Selvam, hauler of other people’s glitter.”

GULL



Night again, ordinary again, which is the plot's true climax.

Bommi nods like a captain acknowledging a calm sea. She mends. She sleeps. She does not dream of clubs.

CHILD

“Akka, the cat is not walking into furniture.”

PURR



The spare net hangs like a steel-and-sari banner.

Rain, when it comes, is not stolen. It is shared badly, as always, but shared. The hamlet's lights hold.

BOMMI

“If the skyline gets thirsty, it can drink rain like the rest of us.”

FLAP



The Bay tells the shore another rumour. Bommi listens, then goes for tea.

A woman with salt in her hair keeps the accounts of light. That is not a miracle. It is work. The work continues, tide after tide, which is the only ending a coast believes.

NARRATOR

“If your city goes dark, check who is shining too hard — then check the fisher who knows nets.”

FADE SURF